

High Elevation Hardwood Forest

PHOTO BY LESLIE EDWARDS, PHD



INDIANA BAT (*MYOTIS SODALIS*)

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IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

High elevation hardwood forests in Georgia have historically provided valuable, large-diameter hardwoods prized for their quality and durability. These forests supported important local economies through selective logging of species like oak, hickory, and maple.

Due to their steep slopes and thin soils, these areas were less accessible, which helped preserve mature stands but also limited large-scale timber harvests. Overharvesting and land conversion reduced some populations, impacting biodiversity and forest structure.

Today, these forests are recognized for their ecological and watershed value, and forestry operations carefully follow BMP guidelines to minimize erosion and protect sensitive habitats during harvest and reforestation.

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Upland hardwood and pine-hardwood forests are found along and north of the fall line. Typically, these habitats form along ridgelines or on other high elevation points. Northern hardwood forests are found in Georgia above 3,500 feet, on some cool, moist, north-facing slopes.

SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

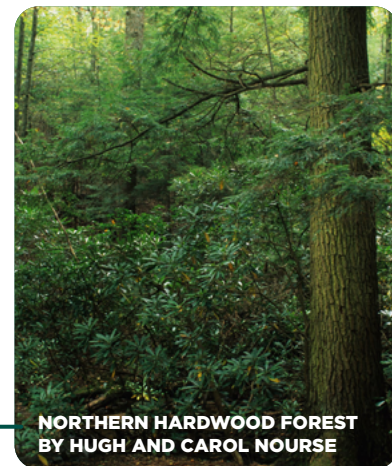
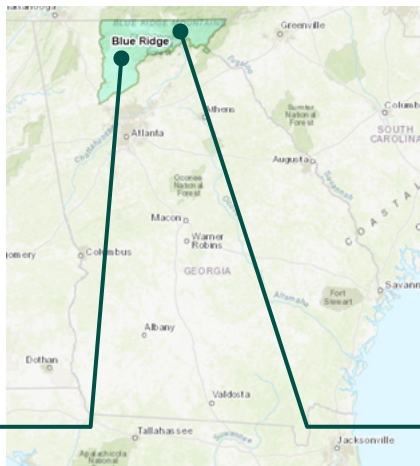
Northern Hardwood Forests

Boulder field Forests

Blue Ridge



**BOULDERFIELD FOREST,
ESTATOAH FALLS, MUD CREEK,
RABUN COUNTY, GEORGIA,
ALAN CRESSLER**



**NORTHERN HARDWOOD FOREST
BY HUGH AND CAROL NOURSE**

THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Use prescribed fire on a 3-5 year rotation to reduce leaf litter, control undesirable woody species, and encourage oak regeneration.
- Avoid offroad vehicle use. When roads or firebreaks are necessary, use Georgia's BMP manual to construct water bars, broad based dips, stream crossings and other practices to reduce erosion and runoff.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

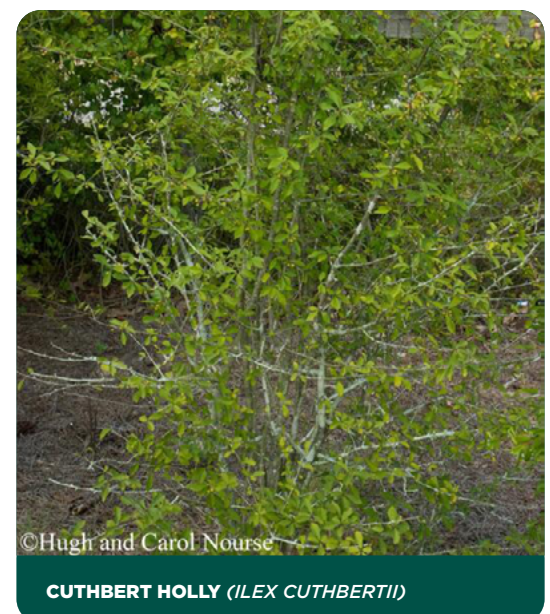
Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources



SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species via QR code to left